

THE NATURE OF LIFE AND THE NATURE OF MAN

Greetings, my dearest friends. May this lecture be a help and an inspiration for every one of you, you who are here, and you who read these words. In tonight's discussion, I should particularly like to stress the relationship between the nature of life and the nature of man. For there is a very direct link. I have often mentioned this; it is not new to you. However, very few people indeed truly understand the full significance of this connection. Their concept of life being an entity in itself, as it were, is so confused and so unrelated to their own innermost personality that they feel that one deals with different aspects here: their personality, their concepts, their feelings or the lack of them, and the way life unfolds for them.

Let us first discuss the nature of life from an absolute, as well as from a relative point of view. When one speaks of life, what is really meant? Does one mean a stretch of years one spends on this planet? Or does one mean the fact that life organisms exist and that one is one of them and senses the wonder of this? Does one think of any particular significance or purpose of life as postulated by the various philosophies or religions? Or does one merely think of a chore life represents which one has to get through as best one can? Does one think of life as essentially favorable? Or does one experience life as a hostile force against man so that man has to defend himself against it? Is life neutral and indifferent to man? Which is it?

Now, life is all of these, my friends, on a relative plane. That is, life will manifest exactly as you believe and conceive of it -- not one iota differently. If your life experience and your conscious concepts are at variance, this is proof that your unconscious concepts must be according to your actual life experience. I cannot stress this emphatically enough, for it is constantly forgotten or glossed over. Nothing could be a better yardstick of your real concepts, attitudes, and feelings than your outer life manifestations in any given area. The moment the correspondence between the hitherto unconscious concepts and feelings and the manifest life experience is established, man is much closer to the nucleus of life within himself. He no longer flounders in ignorance and alienation, believing life and he are two separate factors, not seeing how his life is a direct effect of his feelings and attitudes, which in turn are the result of his concepts of life.

The discovery of the discrepancy of what one consciously believes and his unconscious concepts must always be the first step in the direction towards full selfhood. Life's relative nature is therefore neutral in the sense that it is of such a highly potent, creative, and impressionable substance that it is exactly as moldable as the soul substance, for they are both one and the same substance. Hence, when an individual is convinced that life is a certain thing, life must turn out to be this certain thing. This is not the absolute reality of life though, but the relative reality of the individual in question. Needless to say, this does not apply only to the general overall question of what life is or is not as a whole, but it applies to every particular belief or concept within the framework of a life lived in practical everyday matters. The limits one sees must turn out to be

apparently real. The rules one establishes or blindly follows find their confirmation. Yet, the moment a person discovers that these limits or rules are not unalterable law and can be questioned, the limits recede, and new laws or rules are proven according to the new beliefs which take the place of the old ones.

What is the absolute nature of life as opposed to this relative, moldable one? The answer will become apparent when it is thought, or rather, sensed through to its very essence. Since the life stuff is so moldable, the absolute nature of life must be as limitless as a consciousness can reach out in its concepts. Hence, life is limitless in its possibilities for good, for unfoldment, for yet richer and greater experience. It is not limitless in its possibilities for bad, for the limit is set when life ceases -- or seems to cease. The dreaded ultimate is always nonlife. There is nothing beyond nonlife. This limit of nonlife could only exist on the relative plane, never on the absolute plane. On the absolute plane, life is life, therefore it cannot be nonlife.

So, what man fears most is always and always nonlife, in one form or another. We shall come back to this a little later. Let us for the moment dwell on the nature of life on the absolute plane. Human consciousness is incapable of conceiving of the possibilities that exist for good, for expansion, for unfoldment, for pleasure. The human scope is just too limited for this. However, even the human scope leaves a lot more room for expansion than most human beings avail themselves of. It is only those forms of consciousness which have evolved beyond the human scope, whose experience of life is infinitely greater, wider, deeper, fuller, and limitless in creative experience and joy because their consciousness is capable of embracing more limitless vistas; their concepts expand and expand.

Most human beings' concepts are expandable way beyond their present state so that their life experience could be infinitely richer than what it is. When man is in suffering, discontent, and in inner tension, it is fundamentally always because he deeply senses that more expansion is possible than he avails himself of. And he seeks and searches, and all too often his seeking and searching is in the wrong direction.

Let us now turn in the direction where it is possible to widen the horizon of one's life experience, according to the potentials of each of you who follow this path, so that your life becomes a richer and fuller one. In order to make this possible, your feelings must become alive. In this work and in these lectures, we have often discussed this from various angles and aspects. But how exceedingly difficult it is for man to even find the subtle and hidden area where he discourages the full natural flow of his feelings, where he deliberately numbs them. It is usually easier to become aware of an apparent inability to feel more although at first this too may be covered up by counterfeit feelings. After this first superficial layer is removed -- and many people do not even wish to do this -- a sadness about the "true" lack of feelings is often encountered. The person feels as though he were a cripple who is different from others, "born" with a lesser capacity for rich, warm feelings. But this is never so, and it is always true that a still further hidden level exists in which the process of numbness is instituted very deliberately. When this is uncovered, the path has indeed proceeded very well.

This deliberate numbing occurs because man believes life to be his enemy so that his outreaching and life affirming feelings would deeply involve him with the feared enemy -- life. In order to avoid this, the feelings must be clipped, stilted, hindered. With some individuals, this is true

in certain aspects only, while they are free in other aspects, finding a harmony between their unhampered, spontaneous feelings and life. With others, this is true as an overall attitude to life. Whatever the case may be, the following preposterous, paradoxical situation arises in the human soul. Man fears life as an enemy, which takes his life from him. Since the feelings naturally affirm life, his feelings become his enemy also. Consequently he proceeds to deaden them so that he institutes nonlife deliberately, out of fear of nonlife. As with every issue in the human psyche, this misconception is bound to bring about the very aspect one fears and tries to avoid by defensive means. The defense against a dreaded misconception must be as erroneous as the misconception itself. In this case, that life, as well as these feelings, are hostile forces man needs to guard himself against. The natural feelings are always affirming, outreaching, joyous, and so is life's essence, unhampered by false ideas. Anyone observing a child can observe this natural quality of joyful outreaching and gusto with which it involves itself in life. Only when pain and misconception and misinterpretation of pain arise is his natural flow diverted or stopped altogether.

As life is essentially buoyant, so are the feelings. As life is essentially positive, so are the feelings. As life is essentially rich and involving, so are the natural feelings when they are untampered with. There the immediate correlation is obvious. To the extent a person feels in any given area of his life, in the natural way, unfearful, trustful, and positive, and to the extent he consequently involves himself wholeheartedly, with his total being, bringing the most positive and constructive attitudes and aspects of his personality to bear on the situation, to that extent must his life experience in this particular area be of equal kind.

When man fears life because he suspects it to be against him, he proceeds to numb his feelings. As I have said before, he fears life because he fears nonlife. If you analyze the naked fear of life, it is really a fear of its opposite. I have often mentioned that he who fears life must fear death, and vice versa. But even when we do not think of the physical form of death, but of any other apprehension, by truly analyzing it, it always amounts to a personal annihilation, a personal form of nonlife. Perhaps a person fears a negation of his dignity, of his essential value. Perhaps this is a particular form of nonlife feared. Or perhaps the form of nonlife feared is a denial of wishes. Those original wishes are always striving for a greater form of being alive. Even though the way these wishes are extended in an immature being may be damaging and unrealizable, their essence always remains intact and realizable, provided one takes the trouble to crystallize the essence out of them. Any fear amounts to the opposite of life, in one form or another.

This is going on in practically every human being on this planet. Only the degree varies. There are rare individuals where this preposterous and tragic situation is much less true than with the average person. But it still must exist to some minor extent. For, otherwise, this individual would not be alive in this particular form. The consciousness would not seek this particular form of expression.

When you go deep enough in your work of self-search, my friends, sooner or later you will always discover the area where you hold back, where instead of affirming life and your feelings and instead of expanding with your feelings into life, you negate life and your feelings and retract out of life, out of your feelings, and consequently you lose contact with life. You do not feel at home in it. You feel anxious, persecuted, ill at ease. Negation of life, negation of feelings, and negation of self are all one and the same. And because negation implies nonlife, fear is created. Out of the fear, one proceeds to do the very thing that aggravates the condition of nonlife and nonself.

When you find these areas within yourself, it is a major step. A major step of importance that leads you directly back into yourself. The many, many possibilities existing on this earth for human concern, philosophies, and preoccupation can all be abused to avoid this facing of the area where you and you alone deny life. Often such avoidance does not in the least occur in one's concepts and conscious beliefs, as mentioned before. But where the human experience requires the most direct, spontaneous freedom of feelings, where the joy and the involvement is most immediate and least conceptualizable, it is often there that man resists seeing his impoverishment so that he is unable to find the self-induced stoppage. Blessed are those who are aware of what they miss in life and proceed to remedy the situation.

In what area of your life do you deny life? How do you do this? In what way does this denial take place? Strangely enough, it seems painful to admit such denials until man has reached this total vision of seeing himself. The moment he can really see himself in this negating process, he is already in a more affirming process because he no longer deludes himself about himself.

In order to avoid seeing the negation of the self, of the feelings and of life, of this whole unit, man produces a false self and therefore a false life. In order to create with a false self, a false life, false feelings must be created. This is why people who know the theory of the correlation between self and life, one's concepts and one's experience, often wonder why their experience varies so much from their conscious concepts.

The real is denied and the false substituted -- and this is the answer. This explains the conflicts arising from the false feelings. This is why conflicts seem to be created when one trusts these feelings. It is never the real feelings which produce conflicts. There must always be a denial of something in the self and in the relationship between the self and life or others.

False feelings are created because nothing is as frightening as the numbness. Even though man created the numbness in order to protect himself from the supposed dangers of life, he does not know this, and he is compelled to go on numbing his real feelings. He is equally frightened of awakening his feelings as he is of their deadness. He then proceeds to create false feelings. These false feelings parallel other illusions -- about his spiritual development, his character, his fulfillment, his sufferings, his state of happiness or unhappiness, the reactions of other people to him (either he believes these reactions to be better or worse than they really are).

When I mentioned before that being aware of the deliberate intent to numb feelings, being aware of the poverty of range of feelings, constitutes a major step in self-realization, this is so because the most difficult thing for man to do is to penetrate these various illusions. Most people would rather do anything than that. They go to any length to avoid this. Some find certain aspects only, facets of their idealized self-image, for example, and content themselves with this, not wanting to see the rest of the illusions with which they live and unconsciously believe that they cannot live without. Those people who have reached the point when they no longer fear facing any illusion they may have felt are fortunate indeed. Their path lies before them, unobstructed. From then on, it can only be a question of building up, for the tearing down is over. What must be torn down are only illusions, falseness, never real positivity, affirmation, or constructiveness. Those who are most confused about the real and the false in themselves therefore often believe this pathwork to be destructive or negative. It must appear that way from the point of view of their illusions.

When man suffers an unfulfillment, he hesitates and often even battles against recognition of this fact. For recognizing it would be the admission of nonlife, the admission of unhappiness, the admission of some form of deadness. This in turn brings him face to face with the fact that he has done it, that he fears life, and that he runs from life and himself. Facing this would require him to no longer do this, which he is too fearful to risk. Hence, he remains in the status quo and clings to an illusory life whose pain and waste he is not sufficiently aware of. He does not permit his deep voice to convey the awareness of this pain. He does not dare to risk it because he assumes the ultimate reality of life to be negative, as he fears the ultimate reality of himself to be negative. This is so hard to face that he covers it with illusions to which he clings.

Therefore when man penetrates this illusion and at last sees the negativity lodged in himself, he is a great step nearer salvation than he who clings to the false correct theories about life -- false because he does not really believe them in his heart, the false good feelings or negative ones he produces in order not to be dead, not to be nothing.

It is impossible to eliminate the illusions unless one comes face to face with the discrepancy between what one consciously believes or what one thinks one believes and pays lip service to, and what one believes deep down in one's psyche where the emotions, attitudes, and concepts form a specific expectation of life and create a specific emotional climate. Wherever such negativity exists -- hidden or overt -- one does not trust in the ultimate good of one's own personality and consequently not anyone else's either.

There is a great deal of difference between facing this negativity in the understanding that, "Oh, here it is, here I am in a negative state. Here I am negating rather than affirming. Here I express this negation in this or that specific way," and a justification of this negation as well as a denial of its existence. The latter manifests in a lack of awareness of its existence and a continued talking oneself into the opposite state. The justification manifests by making a life philosophy out of it, by claiming a destructive negative world view as a justification for a personal fear. The fear is therefore denied in its real form. It must always lead back to a personal experience and never a general one. In other words, when people try to expound a nihilistic world view, they hide their private fears, disappointments, and suffering, their distrust in their own innermost self, in their feelings, by making a general rule of life supposedly being bad. This personal experience must be unearthed.

Therefore this pathwork must be concerned with penetrating the illusions, the illusion that says, "I am fulfilled," when one feels unfulfilled; the illusion that says, "The world is bad," when one feels one's feelings are unacceptable or dangerous; the illusion when one ignores a particular unhappiness when this unhappiness exists; the illusion that makes one unaware of how one holds back the spontaneous flow of the natural feelings and in what devious ways this can be accomplished.

Illusion does not only refer to glorifying or beautifying or falsely making a fact more positive than one feels it to be. Nor does it only refer to vague nonfacing, ignoring factors that exist and would need concise acknowledgment in order to bring the personality into balance and truth. It not only means denial and not ascertaining an inner state. Even this not ascertaining may be subtle, for

it may apparently be half admitted without fully seeing it. Illusion also means producing unreal negative emotions. This, too, may be subtle.

Both positive and negative false emotions can be so subtle that it is easy not to admit them. In a more obvious way, false feelings are when one talks himself into a feeling that does not exist at all. In a less obvious way, the rudiments of the particular feeling may actually exist; also, the person would very much want -- on one level of his consciousness -- to feel this particular emotion, but due to the blockage is unable to feel genuinely more than a modicum. Hence, the feeling is manipulated, artificially aggrandized, exaggerated, or dramatized. Again, this may apply to positive or negative emotions.

Dramatizing negative emotions is just as frequent as pretended positive feelings. Usually they go hand in hand and can be found in one and the same psyche. One hangs onto hurts which may be just as illusory as pretended fulfillment or a denied unfulfillment. Anger, hurt, suffering may all be dramatized and clung to. Artificial feelings, both positive and negative, serve the purpose to alleviate the terror of nonfeeling, which is a state of nonlife.

Now, how can you tell the difference between the real feelings and the false feelings, the genuine wellspring of spontaneous life and the drummed up, manufactured emotions instituted as a means of averting a terror? The manufactured feelings are always troublesome and problematic. They do not bring enlightenment and clarification. They do not bring peace of mind. They are a means to avoid an opposite state, hence they must produce more opposites, more irreconcilable poles. For example, a false feeling of excitement and excitation is supposed to ward off numbness, dullness, boredom. The real feeling of aliveness and vibrancy does not avoid anything. It just is. Therefore it contains both stimulation and peace, as I said elsewhere in a different context in an earlier lecture. The false feeling cannot combine apparent opposites such as excitation and peace. They must seem incompatible opposites that cannot be reconciled so that the person is faced with a choice. Often he alternates between these two choices, and he is driven from one extreme to the other. For, a false feeling creates a lack of freedom, enslavement to the false processes set in motion. One no longer chooses either excitation or peace. One is driven to choose the distortions. Being alive becomes a chore, a peace robbing and difficult endeavor. Being peaceful becomes lifeless and finally ends in fright.

False feelings always create problems which are on the dualistic level. Let us take the example of love. The false feeling of love breeds and results in the conflict of submission and slavery, loss of dignity for the sake of giving in, giving up one's own right and desires for the rights and desires of the loved object, so that the way out seems to deny love in order to have one's selfhood intact and one's freedom unhampered. This is the typical conflict of false love, which in turn is produced because one fears the state of nonlife.

There are many, many other such conflicts, all a result of false feelings. Artificial production of positive and negative feelings are both equally damaging, but each breeds different manifestations on the practical level of consciousness. As just said, false positive feelings breed irreconcilable conflicts. False negative feelings, after a time, appear as real negative feelings. They begin to envelop the person and involve him so deeply into them that, although the whole construction is invented, he finds himself unable to come out. This in spite of the fact that, at one point, he was perfectly well aware of the fact that he, in a sense, played a game and deliberately constructed the

false feelings. Let us say it was a fear, or an anger. These feelings seem to keep the psyche alive, as it were. It is not real life, but it seems better than deadness. Although it is initiated purposefully, playfully, deliberately, this is soon forgotten, pushed away, and what was a false anger or a false fear appears as real and becomes much more frightening and peace robbing than a real negative feeling.

You all know that, on this temporary plane of existence, real negative feelings do exist -- real anger, real fear, real hurt. But they never rob the person's peace, at least not for any length of time, beyond the immediate purpose of the specific real feeling. They never weaken the individual. They never drive the individual into a trap from which there is no way out. Real anger can be expressed, as I have often said. It will clear the air. Real fear is a purposeful warning that serves to make the individual cope with a particular situation successfully. And when that situation is over, the person has become stronger. This is not the fact with the false emotion. A real hurt mellows and wisens a person; it makes him grow and expand his horizon. Never can a false, dramatized hurt accomplish this.

Anything that is superfluous and wasteful is always the greatest pain and suffering. No real, genuine emotion, if it is spontaneously and honestly experienced unhampered by the fearful, distrustful, or cunning self, can ever be a waste. It is only the numbing of the real feelings which is a waste, as well as the false feelings, no matter how subtly this may exist in certain areas of the personality. They are the result of a chain reaction which must weaken the self. It must waste life, and it alienates the self from the life center and from the very life processes which are unending and unlimited in their scope and depth of expansion.

It is essential, my friends, that all of you who are working on this path are concerned with and attentive to the false emotions you initiate; that you become more aware of how you constantly do this; how you do not permit yourself to let go and relax into yourself and question yourself, "Now, do I really feel thus and thus? Do I not perhaps put it on?" Once it is put on, it controls you. This is part of your illusions. You must come face to face with those processes where you deny natural life, where you find yourself actually holding back the natural life process, the natural feelings as they want to stream out of you, beautiful, alive, whole -- and you wastefully and ignorantly think you protect yourself by denying them. You think this life process is not safe, that it does not have its own inner wisdom. Now here is where you must be concerned with your development, your growth, your search. When you come to this area in yourself, then you can truly proceed to unlock the door, to learn and see where you sicken yourself needlessly -- sometimes out of a misunderstanding and very often, my friends, out of a subtle spitefulness. The spite that is the result of hurts you have misinterpreted; a spite that is directed against your parents but that now manifests toward life as such and toward anything and anyone that you encounter in your individual life.

Anyone who is face to face with the negativity, who sees how he stops the life process, how he denies his life stream, is therefore nearer to the solution and the salvation than he who denies and ignores his unfulfillments and is oblivious of the fact that they exist and that he has created them through false feelings. And he who lives the false life and the false feelings often believes himself further advanced than he who battles with the actuality of his negation.

Now, my friends, are there any questions in this regard?

QUESTION: Regarding love between a man and a woman, if one's love is not returned, I sometimes feel that loving this person myself is enough. I feel content to love that person. But sometimes I don't feel that way, and I would like my love returned. Now I would like to know where in me is there something wrong?

ANSWER: As I have said again and again, whenever there is something amiss in an outer situation, it is an indication that there is something of exact correspondence inwardly. Since there is no mystery about this and all must be in order, there can only be one answer. There must be something in you that does not want the real fulfillment. You must be divided. There must be a part in you that very much wants the feelings, wants the experience of feeling yourself alive and vibrant with the beauty of such feelings, as only the most dynamic experience on this plane can bring -- love between a man and a woman. But there is the other part where you fear it, perhaps for any number of reasons. If you would not fear and deny it, you truly would not find yourself in such a situation. Your feelings would be directed toward a person who is willing and eager to reciprocate. In fact, it would be unthinkable that your feelings could be elicited, could be ignited in a situation that is one-sided. That in itself indicates an area that there is fear and a denial of life. There may be many reasons for that so that in cases such as this a person finds himself in the predicament that if and when his feelings are unexpectedly returned, his own feelings cool off. When they are not returned, when the other is unreachable, unattainable, the feelings increase and reach out. It is as though the psyche tries to find a compromise between wanting to be alive, wanting to feel the sweetness of life and the fullness of it, but only dares to do so in a fantasy situation, but does not yet have the courage to create it in reality. You have to ascertain that, and why you are frightened of the reality. You have to ascertain that you feel more at ease when the reality situation is much less stimulating, much less inductive of such feelings as the unreal situation. Ascertain that you feel more reassured when you feel in a lesser state of being alive, while this state of feeling threatens you and makes you feel doubtful of being able to cope with it. This doubt is a result of your reluctance to trust your feelings.

QUESTION: How can a person who has a great problem with those manipulated feelings differentiate between the false and the genuine feelings?

ANSWER: The easiest way to do so would be to express every day, deep into the psyche, the wish to become aware of them, to face the fact where this is so. Therefore the attention will focus itself with the help of the inner guidance that automatically manifests when it is truly wanted and activated. When one truly wants to become aware of the false feelings so as to deceive oneself no longer, and states this intent simply and firmly, something is set in motion that will bring this awareness. The more the desire and intent are stated that one wants to live in reality and feel real feelings, the more this will become possible. The more the personality is willing to dispense with deceit and courageously look at what is, the more the guidance and inspiration from the innermost life forces, the inner presence and the wisdom, will manifest without any doubt. The awareness will grow, the attention will focus clearer and with more understanding, and the differentiation will become more obvious. It will show how the one is laborious and the other is easy, how the one leaves one flat and the other brings a warmth and an ease and a vibrancy, no matter how small the feeling may be to begin with. But it warms the whole system, the entire system, the whole person -- body, mind, and soul -- and the spirit. All is in vibrancy with the real feeling. When this decision is made, "This is what I want, this is what I am going to do, this is what I decide -- to live in reality, to see the false, to stop it, and to therefore allow the real to come out -- I know that this decision must

bear its fruits, and I know it is being done," something already begins to change within. This is the way to go about it. Each day to intend it, to say it, to mean it, and to look at what is and decide it, and to call upon the subliminal forces, lodged deep within the real self.

May this lecture give you a new incentive again to see that which is essential. And that which is essential is to see your nonlife, for then and then only can you become alive; to see you in nonfeeling, for then and then only can your real feelings manifest. See this, and live it, and proceed in this direction, and your life will truly be lived purposefully. It will not be lived in vain. It must have its deep fulfillment no matter what outwardly exists or does not exist. He who lives this way lives in reality, and reality will adapt itself eventually and mold itself in an entirely new way.

Be in peace, my friends. Be in God!

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